

Is the environmental impact of using AI concerning?

Posted by u/MopManXD69420 • 0 points • 4 comments

I was watching Ken (on YT) and he briefly brought up not being a fan of AI due to its effect on the environment [here](https://youtu.be/W4c3EZeQw1c?t=385). I'm pretty neutral on the use of AI as my view has been swayed multiple times, so I looked it up and, after reading [Wikipedia's article] (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Environmental_impact_of_artificial_intelligence) on the matter, I'm now pretty concerned

Comments

u/MelodicWallaby4476 • 2 points • 2025-06-22 04:15 UTC

I recommend giving these a read if you want to get a "bigger picture" look at things or a more in-depth view than what's on Wikipedia:

https://www.iea.org/reports/energy-and-ai/ai-and-climate-change

[https://www.energy.gov/sites/default/files/2024-04/AI%20EO%20Report%20Section%205.2g%28i%29_043024.pdf] (https://www.energy.gov/sites/default/files/2024-04/AI%20EO%20Report%20Section%205.2g%28i%29_043024.pdf)

u/ObsidianTravelerr • 2 points • 2025-06-22 02:39 UTC

I'd be more worried about Fracking and other things that are FAR more knowing to cause pollution. The AI thing has a lot of smoke screen and sadly a lot of people against AI keep spouting bullshit or flat out making shit up to try and boogy man things because they would rather lie than go into things with honest numbers.

More and more it seems every claim they make on environmental impact seems to be pure Bullshit or actually related to something else in the area they conveniently ignore to try and get the hate on the Server sights instead.

Don't fall for the fear mongering, that's all this shit is. Suspect everything and always question the intentions behind it.

[https://www.reddit.com/r/aiwars/comments/1l7n8eb/ais_shocking_growth_from_00064_of_energy_use_in/]
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Things that constantly get confused include: US vs. global, energy vs. electricity, data center vs. AI, AI vs. GenAI, projected vs. actual, etc. Here's another fun one that throws everything into doubt: the US houses 33% of the world's data centers, but only just over 4% of the world population. So it's easy to get shocking results for the US, but they effectively serve global AI.

I did the math with "high" values and found it's expected to triple in 2025 to 0.017% of global *energy* use. All the other sources I can find cluster around half of my pessimistic calculation.

Anyone who uses bad analogies doesn't deserve to be listened to ("if AI growth quadruples like I expected, by 2030, global AI power consumption could be enough to power Switzerland for seven months!"). There is no reason to do this unless you're worried your number is too small.

You should never feel bad about individual use:

[<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>)

There's a sanity check here: You can run pretty AI in your own home on a PC and measure power consumption when generating an image or running an LLM query - and then remember that data centers are *vastly* more efficient. If someone says that a ChatGPT query requires three gallons of water and your PC doesn't even heat up, someone made a mistake, and it wasn't you.

Another sanity check: Power isn't free. VC capital is nice, but it can't cover a power bill that size. Even if AI were to use 1% of global electricity with some number of years, that must represent *some massive value being delivered*.

What confuses people is that they seem to think that power consumption ought to be going down and now it's not. But they're thinking of carbon emissions. Power consumption was *never* going down and was *always* going to increase, if only through population growth.

u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 6 points • 2025-06-21 20:58 UTC

Unfortunately, there is a lack of solid information on specific power usage directly going to AI and a lot of the numbers are mixed up with overall data center power usage but from what I've been able to find, if you add up the energy usage specifically dedicated to AI from top companies like Meta, it's equivalent to the power usage of a mid-sized city of around 200,000 people. Is that a lot? Sure but these services are being used by hundreds of millions of people per week so it seems pretty reasonable to me.

Most of the doomer predictions about these usage massively scaling are built upon the assumption that as this technology continues to get more capable, the energy usage of the models will continue to increase when in actuality we're seeing far more use of more efficient models as well as local models which can be run directly on your average PC becoming more and more capable.

It also begs the question of why AI is suddenly such a massive concern when services like social media and video streaming use orders of magnitude more energy and those are apparently not a problem for most people who use those services on a daily basis.